

BRIEF REPORT

Extrinsic Emotion Regulation Motives in Dyads of Friends

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Due to the central role friendships play in young adulthood, it is crucial to understand factors that help foster high-quality bonds. The present study examined associations between extrinsic emotion regulation motives and relationship quality in friendship dyads. A sample of 105 young adult dyads ($N = 210$; $M_{\text{age}} = 19.5$ years, $SD_{\text{age}} = 1.2$ years) completed a survey assessing their motives for engaging in extrinsic emotion regulation with each other and the constructive and destructive behaviors in their friendship. Actor–partner interdependence models indicated motivation to help a friend regulate for prohedonic, relationship maintenance, or emotional similarity reasons predicted more constructive behaviors, whereas contrahedonic motives predicted more destructive behaviors. These effects held from the perspective of the regulator but not the target of the regulation, highlighting the value of dyadic approaches for future work.

Keywords: extrinsic emotion regulation, friendships, motivation, dyadic

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Rachel is elated to hear she has landed her dream job! She shares the news with her friend, Joey, who congratulates her. If Joey is motivated to make her feel good, he might congratulate her enthusiastically. If he is jealous and therefore motivated to dampen Rachel's mood, he might add, "Well, I guess that job wasn't that hard to get." In this interaction, Joey is engaging in extrinsic emotion regulation (ER), the goal-directed process of trying to manage the emotions of someone else (Nozaki & Mikolajczak, 2020). This study examines the association between extrinsic ER motives and constructive and destructive friendship behaviors.

Friendships in Young Adulthood

Over the lifespan, friends play roles of different sizes. In adolescence and young adulthood, friends become important providers of emotional and social support as individuals become more dependent on their peers to help them cope with stressors (Carbery & Buhrmester, 1998; Miljkovitch et al., 2021; Wilkinson, 2010). Due to the heightened emphasis on friendships during this developmental stage, the quality of a young adult's friendships becomes

increasingly predictive of their well-being and identity formation (Nicolaisen & Thorsen, 2017; Pezirkianidis et al., 2023). Thus, it is necessary to consider elements of friendship that might contribute to improved relationship quality.

Previous work has shown positive interpersonal relationships depend on individuals' ability to manage their own and others' emotions (Nozaki & Mikolajczak, 2020). Additionally, the motivation behind an ER attempt has been linked to the effectiveness of one's management of their emotions (Ortner et al., 2022). Comparatively less work, however, has explored why one might attempt to regulate *someone else's* emotions (extrinsic ER motives; Nozaki & Mikolajczak, 2020). The relationship between a regulator and a target can be impacted by a regulator's ER ability (e.g., Riahi et al., 2020), so it is possible that a regulator's motivations behind ER may also matter.

Motivations for Extrinsic Emotion Regulation

There are two categories of extrinsic ER motives: hedonic and instrumental. *Hedonic motives* (prohedonic and contrahedonic) are focused on influencing the ratio of pleasure and pain, whereas

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instrumental motives consider the benefits of emotions beyond the direct experience of them (Tamir, 2016). *Prohedonic motives* seek to increase positive and decrease negative emotions in the target, and they have been linked to higher levels of emotional well-being and greater relational closeness in the regulator (Niven et al., 2012; Springstein et al., 2023). It follows, then, that greater prohedonic motives may be associated with more constructive friendship behaviors. In contrast, *contrahedonic motives* aim to decrease positive and increase negative emotions in the target, and they have been associated with worsened emotional well-being in the regulator (Niven et al., 2012). Thus, individuals may display more destructive friendship behaviors if one friend aims to make the other friend feel worse.

A variety of instrumental motives can drive extrinsic ER. Here, we focus on those that center on social concerns given they are the most relevant to relationship functioning (Eldesouky & English, 2019; Tran et al., 2025). Close others may regulate each other's emotions to maintain the relationship, to be emotionally similar, or to help another make a good impression (Springstein et al., 2023). *Relationship maintenance motives* aim to improve or maintain one's relationship and have been associated with greater relational well-being in the regulator (Eldesouky & English, 2019; Springstein et al., 2023). Thus, greater relationship maintenance motives may be associated with more constructive friendship behaviors. The motivation to achieve a state of *emotional similarity* with one's friend may also predict greater constructive friendship behaviors. For example, one study found more emotionally similar couples provided more effective emotional and instrumental support (Verhofstadt et al., 2008). Further, an experience sampling study found emotional similarity motives predict better relational well-being for the regulator (Springstein et al., 2023). Finally, motivation to regulate a friend's emotions may involve factors beyond the friendship, such as aiming to help a friend maintain or improve their social status (*impression management motives*). If a friend appears more concerned with their friend's social status than with their friend's emotional state, they may be perceived as being less responsive. Given perceived partner responsiveness is an important predictor of relational well-being (Reis & Gable, 2015), impression management motives may be associated with destructive friendship behaviors.

The Present Study

The present study examined associations between extrinsic ER motives and friendship behaviors in emerging adults. We hypothesized prohedonic, emotional similarity, and relationship maintenance motives would predict more constructive relationship behaviors for the regulator, but in consideration of nuanced friendship experiences, not necessarily fewer destructive relationship behaviors. Contrahedonic and impression management motives were hypothesized to predict more destructive relationship behaviors for the regulator. We employed a dyadic approach to explore whether effects extend beyond the regulator to the target of the regulation.

Method

Transparency and Openness

Data and R analysis code can be found at <https://osf.io/arnp9> (Gross et al., 2025). See Supplemental Material for all measures. This study was not preregistered. Originally, the sample size was

determined based on resource availability, with the final sample size ultimately limited by the response rates of friends invited to participate by in-lab participants. We then ran a post hoc power analysis using APIMPowerR software (Ackerman & Kenny, 2016). With a sample size of 105 indistinguishable dyads ($N = 210$), with an α of .01, we had a power of 0.98 to detect an actor effect of size .30 (i.e., a β of .300 or a partial r of .301). Power analyses were aimed to examine actor effects, but for our exploratory analysis of partner effects, we had 0.399 power to detect a partner effect of size .15 (i.e., a β of .150 or partial r of .156).

Participants and Procedure

Between November and December 2022, undergraduates were recruited via a research participant pool. Following informed consent, participants provided contact information for a close friend and then completed a survey evaluating their motivations for managing their friend's emotions and the constructive and destructive behaviors in their friendship. Afterward, the participant's friend received a link to an online survey with the same friendship-related measures. The participant and the friend were thereon considered a dyad. Participants received course credit, while elected friends received a \$5 gift card or course credit for their participation.

The original sample contained 328 individuals. However, some elected friends did not complete the study, so the participants who nominated them were not part of a dyad ($N = 92$) and were therefore excluded from analyses. Dyad members who reported being in a romantic relationship with each other ($N = 26$) were also excluded. Thus, the final sample included 210 individuals (105 dyads). The sample contained primarily women (67%; 29% men) and was diverse (48% White, 24% East Asian, 10% Black, 10% South Asian). Participants were 18–23 years old, with an average age of 19.5 years ($SD = 1.2$ years).

Measures

Extrinsic Emotion Regulation Motives

The Emotion Regulation Goals Scale (Eldesouky & English, 2019) was modified to assess extrinsic motives and include emotional similarity motives (Eldesouky et al., 2025). Participants were asked, "When you are regulating [the close friend]'s emotions, how often do you do so because you want" and were presented with a series of 38 items about motives.¹ They rated their frequency of regulating their friend's emotions for each reason from 1 (*never*) to 7 (*always*). These items assessed five distinct motives: prohedonic (12 items; e.g., "To make them feel more positive emotion"; $\alpha = .94$), contrahedonic (11 items; e.g., "To make them feel more negative emotion"; $\alpha = .82$), relationship maintenance (five items, e.g., "To get along with my partner"; $\alpha = .90$), emotional similarity (six items, e.g., "To help us have a similar emotional experience"; $\alpha = .84$), and impression management (four items, e.g., "To help my partner avoid being rejected by others"; $\alpha = .90$).

¹ We collected data on self-focused motives, for example, "To feel more positive emotion (e.g., joy, contentment) myself," but do not include them as that is beyond the scope of the present study.

Table 1
Correlation Table of Variables of Interest

Variable	M	SD	A-P	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
1. Prohedonic	5.05	1.14	.22** [.08, .34]	—						
2. Contrahedonic	1.31	0.51	.11 [-.03, .24]	.02 [-.11, .16]	—					
3. Relationship maintenance	4.14	1.49	-.07 [-.20, .07]	.51** [.40, .60]	.10 [-.04, .23]	—				
4. Impression management	2.88	1.44	.39** [.26, .50]	.39** [.27, .50]	.31** [.19, .43]	.44** [.32, .54]	—			
5. Emotional similarity	3.22	1.08	.08 [-.06, .21]	.41** [.29, .51]	.30** [.18, .42]	.58** [.48, .66]	.51** [.40, .60]	—		
6. Constructive behaviors	5.51	0.91	.42** [.30, .52]	.40** [.27, .50]	-.01 [-.15, .13]	.19** [.06, .32]	.15* [.02, .28]	.22** [.09, .35]	—	
7. Destructive behaviors	2.07	0.81	.40** [.28, .51]	.04 [-.09, .18]	.17* [.04, .30]	.14* [.01, .27]	.17* [.03, .30]	.07 [-.07, .20]	.12 [-.02, .25]	—

Note. All responses (actor and partner) are included. Emotion regulation motives and behaviors were assessed from 1 (*never*) to 7 (*always*). Values in brackets represent 95% confidence intervals. A-P represents correlation between actor and partner responses.

* $p < .05$. ** $p < .01$.

Friendship Behaviors

Selected items from the Network of Relationships Inventory Social Provision Version (Furman & Buhrmester, 1985) were used to assess constructive relationship behaviors (seven items; e.g., “How much do you play around and have fun with this person?”; $\alpha = .81$) and destructive relationship behaviors (six items; e.g., “How much do you and this person get upset with or mad at each other?”; $\alpha = .85$).² Participants reported the frequency of these behaviors in their friendship on a scale from 1 (*never*) to 7 (*always*). The two subscales were not significantly correlated (Table 1), indicating representation of distinct constructs.

Data Analytic Plan

Using data from both partners, we employed actor-partner interdependence modeling (Kenny et al., 2006) to test associations between ER motives and friendship behaviors. Actor-partner interdependence modeling yields both an actor effect (e.g., the regulator’s motive associated with the regulator’s quality rating of behaviors) and a partner effect (e.g., the regulator’s motive associated with the target’s rating of behaviors) while controlling for one another, allowing us to examine patterns across dyads. All predictors were grand-mean centered. Since the motives were significantly correlated (see Table 1), we ran separate actor-partner interdependence modeling for each of the five motives to avoid oversaturation of the model. We controlled for Type I error using the Bonferroni correction method. Since five different ER motives were being tested, the significance level for each individual test was set to $p < .01$ (Andrade, 2019). In other words, the total significance level (0.05) was divided by the number of tests (five), resulting in a more stringent threshold of 0.01 for each test. Exploratory analyses were conducted to test the potential moderating role of gender on the individual or dyadic level (i.e., same-gender vs. mixed-gender dyads), and time spent interacting, but none of these variables moderated the effects.

Results

Prohedonic motives were the most frequently reported, followed by relationship maintenance and emotional similarity. Contrahedonic motives were relatively uncommon (Table 1).

Constructive Friendship Behaviors and Emotion Regulation Motives

We hypothesized prohedonic, relationship maintenance, and similarity motives would predict more constructive relationship behaviors. Results supported these hypotheses in that regulator reports of constructive relationship behaviors were higher in those who more strongly endorsed prohedonic motives ($b = .32$, $SE = .05$, $p < .001$), relationship maintenance motives ($b = .11$, $SE = .04$, $p = .006$), and emotional similarity motives ($b = .18$, $SE = .06$, $p = .003$).

² We collected data on two more items from this scale: “How close are you with this person?” and “How frequently do you interact with this person?” However, we did not include these in the current analyses because they do not fit into either the constructive or destructive behavior categories we aimed to assess.

for regulating their friend's emotions. However, when examining the target of the regulator's reports of constructive behavior, we found no significant associations for prohedonic motives ($b = .11$, $SE = .05$, $p = .03$), relationship maintenance motives ($b = .05$, $SE = .11$, $p = .65$), or emotional similarity motives ($b = .09$, $SE = .06$, $p = .12$). As shown in Table 2, all other effects were not significant.

Destructive Friendship Behaviors and Emotion Regulation Motives

We hypothesized contrahedonic and impression management motives would predict more destructive relationship behaviors. As expected, contrahedonic motives were significantly associated with destructive relationship behaviors reported by the regulator ($b = .26$, $SE = .10$, $p = .009$), but this effect was not present in target reports ($b = -.04$, $SE = .10$, $p = .67$). Contrary to our hypothesis, impression management motives were not associated with destructive relationship behaviors from the perspective of the regulator ($b = .07$, $SE = .04$, $p = .08$) or the target ($b = .06$, $SE = .04$, $p = .13$). No other effects emerged (see Table 2).

Discussion

This study examined how motives behind extrinsic ER are related to behaviors in young adult friendships. As hypothesized, regulating a friend's emotions for prohedonic, relationship maintenance, or emotional similarity reasons predicted more constructive behaviors. Friends with greater contrahedonic motives reported greater destructive

relationship behaviors, consistent with prior work suggesting the negative impact of contrahedonic motives on relational well-being (Springstein et al., 2023). Contrary to our hypothesis, stronger impression management motives did not predict more destructive relationship behaviors, possibly because regulators see themselves as helpful. This is consistent with previous work showing one's perspective on the situation and regulation attempt can significantly affect its outcomes (Levy-Gigi & Shamay-Tsoory, 2017; Niven et al., 2019; Ruan et al., 2024).

Associations between extrinsic ER motives and behaviors in friendships were observed only from the perspective of the regulator. Although these findings are surprising given work showing ER attempts impact both members of a dyad (Kinkead & Salas Riquelme, 2022), they are in line with evidence suggesting a gap between the application and receipt of ER (Pauw et al., 2025). A regulator might perceive the relationship as better due to their efforts to improve a friend's emotions, but this attempted support may not be apparent to the target if the efforts are unappreciated. Alternatively, perceiving oneself as being in a constructive relationship may motivate prohedonic motives regardless of the target's view. This discrepancy may also be explained by the differential success of ER attempts (Niven et al., 2009, 2024; Springstein & English, 2024). Specifically, if an ER attempt fails, the target may not notice it, leading to a disconnect between regulation motives and other behaviors. Motives may also impact relational outcomes more indirectly, such as through their influence on strategy selection (Ortner et al., 2022), so future work should explore other motivational components of ER in dyads.

Table 2

Extrinsic Emotion Regulation Motives Predicting Friendship Behaviors Using Actor–Partner Interdependence Modeling

ER motive	Constructive behavior					Destructive behavior				
	<i>b</i>	<i>SE</i>	<i>t</i> value	<i>p</i>	95% CI	<i>b</i>	<i>SE</i>	<i>t</i> value	<i>p</i>	95% CI
Prohedonic										
Intercept	5.49	.07	82.29	<.001		2.02	.07	30.25	<.001	
Actor	0.32	.05	6.31	<.001	[.22, .41]	0.01	.05	0.20	.84	[−.09, .12]
Partner	0.11	.05	2.23	.03	[.01, .21]	0.07	.05	1.27	.17	[−.03, .16]
Contrahedonic										
Intercept	5.49	.08	71.9	<.001		2.02	.07	30.84	<.001	
Actor	−0.07	.11	−0.58	.56	[−.29, .16]	0.26	.10	2.66	.009	[.07, .46]
Partner	−0.01	.11	−0.05	.96	[−.23, .22]	−0.04	.10	−0.42	.67	[−.24, .15]
Relationship maintenance										
Intercept	5.49	.08	73.43	<.001		2.02	.07	29.88	<.001	
Actor	0.11	.04	2.83	.006	[.03, .19]	0.07	.04	2.06	.04	[.00, .14]
Partner	0.05	.11	0.45	.65	[−.16, .26]	−0.11	.09	−1.18	.20	[−.30, .07]
Emotional similarity										
Intercept	5.48	.07	74.73	<.001		2.02	.07	30.12	<.001	
Actor	0.18	.06	3.08	.003	[.06, .29]	0.05	.05	0.99	.33	[−.05, .15]
Partner	0.09	.06	1.63	.12	[−.02, .21]	−0.07	.05	−1.35	.18	[−.17, .03]
Impression management										
Intercept	5.49	.08	73.32	<.001		2.02	.07	30.9	<.001	
Actor	0.08	.04	1.73	.09	[−.01, .16]	0.07	.04	1.8	.08	[−.01, .15]
Partner	0.05	.04	1.21	.23	[−.03, .14]	0.06	.04	1.52	.13	[−.02, .14]

Note. All predictors were grand mean centered prior to analyses. Actor effects represent the association between the regulator's ER motives and the regulator's perceptions of behaviors in the friendship, whereas partner effects represent the association between the regulator's motives and the target's perception of behaviors in the friendship. We controlled for Type I error using the Bonferroni correction method, where a result was considered significant if $p < .01$ (Andrade, 2019). Statistically significant effects are in bold. ER = emotion regulation; b = unstandardized effects from actor–partner interdependence models; SE = standard error; CI = confidence interval.

This study was cross-sectional, so causal claims could not be made. Future research should experimentally manipulate ER motives to test how they impact observed relationship behaviors and collect longitudinal data to determine how ER motives evolve as relationships develop. The present study also had low power to detect partner effects, which tend to be smaller in this area (e.g., Velotti et al., 2016), so the null partner effect findings should not be overly extrapolated. Additionally, the sample was drawn from a midwestern university, which limits the generalizability of our findings. Research in different cultural contexts or with older adults could reveal unique dynamics. For example, in a collectivist culture where greater value is placed on interpersonal harmony, impression management motives may be associated with greater constructive relationship behaviors.

The present study presents a novel investigation into the motivations behind extrinsic ER attempts and behaviors in young adult friendships. Hypotheses were largely supported but revealed differences in perspective between the regulator and target, highlighting a potential communication gap and the value of dyadic approaches to ER.

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